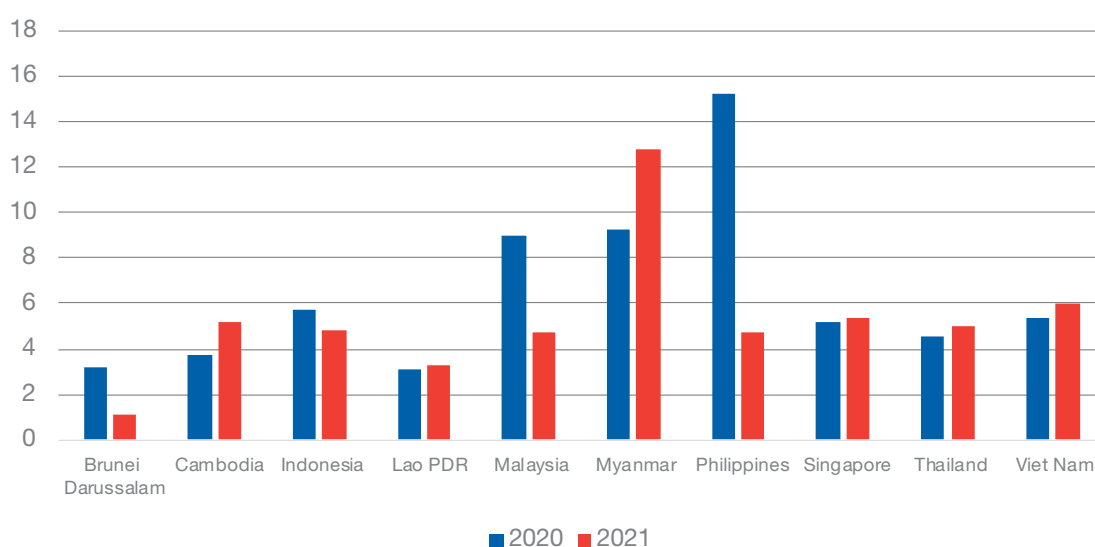


2020 and 2021, and, for approximately half of AMS, working hours lost were higher in 2021 compared to 2020 (Figure 1.3). The disruptions in global supply chains because of travel and transport restrictions hit some AMS particularly hard because of supply needs from other countries.

Despite these tremendous job losses, many countries also experienced labour shortages due to previously unprecedented demand for certain products, such as rubber gloves in Malaysia and for fishery products in Thailand. The return of migrant workers to their home countries contributed to significant labour shortages (Lee and David, 2021; Sriring and Staporncharnchai, 2021).⁴ COVID-related movement restrictions caused many workers to withdraw from the labour force (especially women) and labour force participation rates declined in most countries.⁵ This was the case for Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines, and Viet Nam (Figure 1.4). According to the ILO (2021c), female employment in AMS in 2020 was 3.9 percent lower than the expected level, which is markedly less than the 2.7 percent figure for male employment.⁶ The impact of the pandemic on employment is evident in lower labour force participation, lower working hours, and higher unemployment rates in most countries (Figure 1.5).

Figure 1.3. Decline in weekly working hours compared to 2019 (percent)



Source: ILO (2022a)

- 4 There are of course long-standing reasons for the labour shortages in these sectors, which accounts for their high reliance for migrant workers, including poor working conditions, that is prone to abuse, and lack of attractiveness for local workers (Looi, 2020; Ng, 2020; ILO, 2015).
- 5 McKinsey Global Institute (2020) estimates that at the beginning of the pandemic, women accounted for more than half of total job losses from COVID-19 though they made up only two-fifths of the global labour force. This is because they are overrepresented in sectors hardest hit by the pandemic: accommodation and food services; retail and wholesale trade; and other services, such as arts, recreation, and public administration.
- 6 This is equivalent to saying there is greater increase in unemployment or inactivity for women compared to men. According to the report, one reason is the increase in unpaid care responsibilities for women as schools closed (ILO, 2021c).